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FROM HER TO ETERNITY

APRIL 2026
MASTER OF FINE ARTS
KONSTFACK

prologue

This essay served my cause so far as a catalogue of sorts – a means to sort and set the snippets of thoughts and references accompanying my artistic process. It is divided to three parts, as there were three parts of the exhibition with nine gaps between them. The intention here is to stretch an array of fine threads, allowing the gaze to follow their dainty bodies towards the next point of contact. The name of the essay comes from an album appearing in *Wings of Desire* – right after the invisible protagonist gets startled by his own passing reflection.

It is one the first references I acquired during a discussion about a relative value of a memory, monuments and allergies – and which I keep close to my heart to this very day.

chasing the gaze

What stroke me first – or rather second, right after an unholy sneeze caused by blooming poplar trees– was the light. The Birdlady had no means of reflecting it, the cast aluminium surface oxidized by years of rain and something else – yet piercing my watery eyes with the same kind of vigour that once probably emanated from its presence. There couldn't be a better day to stumble across it – I was in a light, reminiscent mood, prone to observation and equipped with swollen eyes that tend to see every piece of world anew, creating a sort of rhythm in the moments of recognition and imagination.

On schooldays, the foothold of the Birdlady filled a specific niche in my life. It was a place of departure, or rather place of awaiting, which usually comes with its own set of rules and intimacy. The daily commute was provided by my grandfather after he finished working at the nearby swimming pool. His occupational placement changed constantly, mostly according to weather and season of the year. Just as anyone who's work is affected by wits of nature and time, he was left out wondering about the seasons to come, preparing for different scenarios and sequences of scenarios that could (God forbid) result in unnecessary spending. Swimming pool meant the end of the yearly cycle, the end of planning. When I think about it, I don't ever recall seeing the area outside of summertime, until I stared to date a girl that lives nearby. The year-round observance provided me with insights that I would like to share.

To this day I'm quite suspicious that the exposure to the Birdlady shaped my own archetype of sculpture as a medium – even though I don't remember trying to decipher its meaning or even observe it closely. The reason behind my avoidant gaze may have laid in its reciprocity; and while the placement provided some daily traffic, it wasn't very welcoming for a prolonged venture. Most of the public spaces *bristled with monuments* in one way or another, thanks to a long-forgotten law that secured a part of the procurement budget to this cause. (Auge, 1995) Its formal decisions bore all the signs of a sculpture intended for this very purpose – abstract enough to engage the perceptive potential of the passing pupils – yet still seeping with the subtle tragedy of enlightenment. Furthermore, it was quite PG13 in comparison with plague pillars and depictions of saints scattered around the old town where I originally grew up.

Since a *gaze is a look driven by need* - and as there wasn't much to look at – I propose a possibility to read the intention as an evasion manoeuvre. (Geczy,2021) Considering the Lacan's *objet petit a* as a signifier for the constantly updating nature of desire, I can at least rule out the quality of ontological present as a culprit our mutual avoidance.

> *“It is in as much as, at the heart of the experience of the unconscious, we are dealing with that organ—determined in the subject by the inadequacy organized in the castration complex—that we can grasp to what extent the eye is caught up in a similar dialectic. From the outset, we see, in the dialectic of the eye and the gaze, that there is no coincidence but, on the contrary, a lure. When, in love, I solicit a look, what is profoundly unsatisfying and always missing is that—you never look at me from the place from which I see you. Conversely, what I look at is never what I wish to see.”* (Lacan, 1973, p.102)

The organ mentioned in this case manifests a symbol of lack – describing something unattainable, somehow a perpetually failing potential to overcome its unconscious origin. If the lure represents a proposal, is the gaze doomed to never reach its expectations? What a beautiful definition of a romance! Usually, while confronting the psychoanalytical notions on love, I cannot shake off a feeling that I am looking through a set of binoculars, somehow both ways at the same time. Wobbling on a 3-meter ladder in front of the sculpture made me realize that I was probably one of the few people that have crossed its scopic field in years. What a beautiful definition of a romance! Apparently, approaching beyond through an inanimate object is a practice that works in one way or another – even through strictly secular lens.

It was quite later on, that I discovered an English term for a mass; surely the ambiguity would amuse me with its suggestiveness. Nevertheless, the Sunday mass was one of my first true masses encountered – or rather my first memory of the residues that necessarily come with ~~and after~~ them. The usual spot was St. Stephens church run by the capuchin order. Apart from the strategic position across my grandmother’s office, it was chosen for its slightly more uplifting sermons and occasional appearance of a mysterious guitar player that accompanied the choir on the more rhythmical pieces. Bored and accompanied by my grandmothers high pitched singing voice I unknowingly created the first of many trapdoors; where chance - the eternal employee of the month - has always its finger on the trigger mechanism. These days I’m already familiar with the scent of pure *naphthalene*. It is mostly known as the pesticide in mothballs, although nowadays it is gradually replaced by somewhat safer alternatives. It is also a very common additive in the petrochemical production – if you happen to find yourself near a plastic manufacturing plant, take a deep whiff. The scent between chlorine and gasoline – that’s it!

However, my first encounters with it were amongst the crowd, in an amalgamation layered with stuffy fur coats, frankincense, and Pitralon – a popular aftershave originating from former GDR. Nowadays, I tend to notice the smell as I arrive to my girlfriend's apartment after a longer period spent elsewhere. It can linger for years; its chemical composition binds extremely well with porous materials – and I currently feel quite porous in this regard.

Our favourite seating was on the far left, near the entrance, with the best view and less responsibility compared to the more frontal positions - where improper singing or restlessness often resulted in all sorts of little injustices. The sculpture of St. Stephen; the patron of the church lived in a low niche in the right-side wall between the second half of The Stations of the Cross. Since the figure wasn't busy with any sort of physical torment, he quickly became the embodiment of the so often mentioned nurturing shepherd. Additionally, he gained my trust by being a prominent historical figure of the region, anchoring his existence outside the realms of hearts and souls. Mimicking his static gaze upward made him into a slanted mirror for a gaze of my own – amplifying and projecting it higher than I ever could without tilting my head too far back, which would surely cause too many waves in my surrounding pool.

Thanks to my empirical upbringing the produced stare was subjected to the same set of rules as any other kind of information transfer would – the quality of the signal depended on a well thought out position and clarity of the shared content. Additionally, judging by the density of the surrounding crowd; the premises were deemed to be a place of admirable reception. I guess that most transitional spaces are powered by a similar kind of a liminal charge - predominantly generated by the friction between private and collective, or any other kind of opposing forces.

> *''Thus we can contrast the realities of transit (transit camps or passengers in transit) with those of residence or dwelling; the interchange (where nobody crosses anyone else's path) with the crossroads (where people meet); the passenger (defined by his destination) with the traveller (who strolls along his route - significantly, the SNCF still calls its customers travellers until they board the TGV; then they become passengers), the housing estate ('group of new dwellings', Larousse says), where people do not live together and which- never situated in the centre of anything (big estates characterize the so-called peripheral zones or out skirts), with the monument where people share and commemorate; communication (with its codes, images and strategies) with language (which is spoken).* (Auge, 1995, p.107-108)

My current residence provides me with a sufficient daily dose of time and visual references to reflect on the transitional spaces, and its inanimate dwellers – set in stone, or something else – occupying them. They remind us about the movement that we are about to experience – as well as the fact that there is something else awaiting – a *non-movement* perhaps. If so, then they might be the ones to blame for a subtle discomfort usually experienced at such places – as well as for the deliberate surrender to the invisible forces dragging us towards the exit passages just as we conclude our business. Generally, these forces are difficult to notice, since they are deeply rooted in the fundamental design principles of such spaces; just as industrial smokestacks are engineered to use atmospheric differences as means to improve updraft. What in this case sets them apart is the intentionally placed obstructions in the otherwise smooth flow. Paradoxically, the permanence of a monument acts as a necessary reminder of our own temporality and providing the body with point of reference within the continually transforming landscape. On the other hand, the same longevity that equips them with a reflective potential; often results in an acquisition of a different sets of roles over their lifespan. The intended meanings dissolve into the everydayness, resulting in identity bastards, while the remnants of their previous existence remain kept by the sightseeing guides and speaking only a more exclusive ~~transitioning~~ audience. Yet, the newly earned names appear often truer in some sense – truer through the lens of an average experience; sort of commoner eye that sees the world in its suggestively - and provide language with such linguistic jewels as the word pineapple.

The Birdlady has a real name as well, even though it served me a little to no purpose outside of this essay. In 1983 sculptor Emil Venkov unveiled a *Desire to fly* next to the quite recently opened educational complex which served as an employment pool for the neighbouring oil refinery. While the sculpture was still formally adherent to the popular canon of its time, it certainly spoke in the future tense. Judging by its soaring name, it was always intended as a timeskip arc. And it did quite well in that regard. Compared to its effectively built surroundings, the Birdlady was aging quite well. Protected by her ambiguity and location; the aluminium body merely changed shade and gathered few markings – an unavoidable rite of passage for any structure within these parts of the town. You could consider it a very successful project in some ways as the *permanence* is the most primal desire a monument can have. As a chapter conclusion, this feels a little too anticlimactic. Like a passenger missing his last train already late for an interview as a train conductor.

Still, “I couldn’t help but wonder: Can you get to a future if your past is present?” (Parker, 1999-2004)

irritation – chlorine and residue

I have always had extremely delicate skin. Not in the physical sense, but prone to irritation especially around my face, hands and neck. There was never an answer to what caused the blooms on the surface, yet there were clues pointing towards a bespoke collection of allergies which were progressively discovered during my early childhood. The creases on my arms gradually became landscapes of temporary sweat pools –symmetrical by the planar array of joints and skin, quite resembling of antique hand-coloured naval maps with slightly deeper shades of pigments around the edges. At certain times, the sensation became unbearable. Whilst providing a short relief, the skin was far too brittle to withstand the reoccurring frantic scratching and eventually yielded. The little wounds filled with salt and minerals during the summer heat resulted in everlasting search for shade and means of cooling down.

Still waters in the lake and cutoff meanders of the river suffered from algae bloom and overgrown colonies of microorganisms.

Moving water bore suspended particles of river mud.

The worst of the bunch was the water from public swimming pools.

The lukewarm water left a residue of sorts – a thin film that rooted itself in widened pores and pulled them closer to each other.

As I got older these blooms became less frequent in occurrence; my skin got tougher and I could finally enjoy the forbidden pleasures of honey and milk – which to this day occupy a high position in my food pyramid. Apparently, this is a common phenomenon regarding the infant allergies – you sort of grow out of it. They never quite disappear though; an occasional patch still resurfaces on my supraorbital ridge – equipping me with a set of lenses that remain sharp but are long outdated.

During the 1950s, the former government started to look for means to diversify its earnings while utilizing its prominent geographical position. The Apollo refinery was destroyed during the war, and there was an increasing pressure on building its successor. Fast. Sandy beds that circled the Danube River were in this case perceived as an economic accelerator– allowing for significantly shorter building times. The former structure stood on a massive granite bedrock – although for the most a bit too close to the city centre. Fisherman in the river canals complained about their daily catch stinking of kerosene, but the company hushed the allegations with sponsorship to the fishing association. Period records show that the leakage was truly minimal – its proximity and exposure resulted in a somehow balanced relationship between the company officials and the town residents, where each side kept the other one on their toes. (Jancura,2022)

It is hard to interpret the newly formed structure without the awe it surely produced. Residents from the surrounding settlements gathered in eager to witness the first flames emerging from the fresh chrome-plated exhausts. Gathering the same way, as they would for pastorals or new satirical play at the national theatre a few years ago. I like to imagine that newly hired workers – often drawn from secluded settlements – shared a part of an experience with Adso of Melk, overwhelmed by vivid hallucinations when first entering the abbeys library; dazzled by stained glass and shadowless bas-reliefs. Just as Abbot Suger debated the new form of a gothic temple as a source of light and transformation—albeit slightly more nineteeneightyfoursesque, or rather a *Warhammer 40k* lore. (Eco, 1980)

The dislocation of the successive complex changed this balance drastically – where secluded and out of sight it was left to grow, age and fail without much oversight. Those days it was only observed by its employees - which were fully dependent on its operation - and a stubborn community of gardeners encircling the immerse complex. It was them, who first started to report the slimy substances in their shallow wells, pushing the guilty parties to investigate the bowels of the now adolescent structure. The substance in this case was *Sphaerotilus natans* – a bacterial peripethon often found in contaminated rivers with high organic loading. The soft sand bed once perceived as a logistical advantage—turned into a cumulative sponge, absorbing and spreading the offspring of a great leaking body. (Shildrick, 1997) The following measurements estimated the annual leak of about 10 000 tons of crude oil. Since a new drinking water source was established nearby, there was a justified concern of a total contamination. Precautionary measures were taken but without much success. The water was deemed unsafe to consume or to wash with.

This stage is in the industry mostly referred to as an *infant stage*. The issues accompanying this stage don’t stem from the material degradation or failure – more often they are results of a poorly tested systems implemented without enough secondary safety measures.

Around the same period began the substantial investment into the surrounding infrastructure. Housing, leisure areas, schools and sports ground were built in a span of just few years – a never-seen-before form of benefits exclusive to the refinery employees. As expected, the rumours of privileged living conditions started to attract increasing numbers of newcoming workers; finally satisfying the increasing needs of the expanding complex. The residual heat from the distillation process provided the housing units with cheap, reliable heating source and even enabled the affiliate school to build a massive recreational pool. Due to its popularity and the polluted water, it was permanently exposed to high levels of chlorination to retain the hygienic standards. The yellow tiles that came in contact with the treated water had gradually lost their sheen and gained a crystal-like residue over its glaze. Supposedly this kind of slag is usually composed of chemicals, mineral deposits and organic matter in equal parts. Touching it results in a bizarre sensation – instantly absorbing every last bit of moisture and natural body oils, drying out the skin completely.

During the coming years, the urgency of this catastrophe pushed the authorities to action – a somewhat effective emergency plan that contained the spread of petrochemical residues, lowering the contamination of the area to certain extent.

When C. Collodi published *the Adventures of Pinocchio* in 1883, it gained a massive following almost instantaneously; partially due to the fact that it reflected on the important issues accompanying migration of the young Italians to larger cities as a result of developing industrialization. Despite the popular belief it wasn't Geppetto who found the enchanted log; but Master Antonio – a local carpenter who wanted to turn the piece of wood it into a table leg. When Geppetto approached him with his new business endeavour – to become a puppeteer and travel the country performing for children – master Antonio provided him with the mischievous log he was already fed up with; and which in a span of a neighbourly visit provided reasons for a short tempered Geppetto to start two consecutive fights. As the poor man worked on the little marionette, he grew impatient of Pinocchio's nose and left in a disproportionate scale, moving to the other parts of puppet's apparatus. As soon as the animated body gained a functional set of legs, it vanished to explore the world in its unfinished state. The prolonged nose - seemingly left out as a grabbing handle by his creator as he grew suspicious of his unruly character - became Pinocchio's primary recognizable feature. Serving as a control measure for his surroundings and making him transparent in his speech and action.as he was instantly confronted with his decisions. Even with the help of the instantaneous morality meter, the original story concludes with Pinocchio being hanged from a tree by the Fox and the Cat – the characters that have previously led him astray from the path of good fortune. In this story Pinocchio succumb to the traps of the word – to greed and deceit; never overcoming his role of a miracle that was hastily carved with a hot hand – not thinking about consequences of using a miracle as a source material of his first creation

instead of a regular log.
Yet, there is a second ending. One where the marionette becomes a part of the living world, and instead of calling for Father with his last breath; observes his former body lifeless, sitting on a chair with *its arms hanging limp*. (Collodi, 1904)

reading the plinth

Earlier this year, I stumbled upon an article in the municipal sculpture register regarding the *Desire to fly,* written by a mysterious author signed only as SJ. Apart from the historical and technical aspects of the sculpture it contained a short formal reading. Overall, the author considers the *composition lacking* and its *logical anchoring to the base* questionable. (SJ, 2022) At this point, I need to to set some terms more firmly that I'm used to – even though I usually enjoy the thrill of observing terminological confusion .Usually, the plinth, base and pedestal are used as synonyms, but their subtle differences in translation have unknowingly served as an activation formula ~~and an obstacle~~ of discussions accompanying the artistic process. Thankfully, Jack Burnham divides them by an intelligible key:

The base is the greatest mass, upon which a sculpture rests.

The pedestal is a shaftlike form which elevates the sculpture.

The plinth is a flat planar support which separates the sculpture from the ground.

(Burnham, 1972,p.20)

It might have been the authors negligence or the lack of key; yet from the *anchoring to the base*, it is hard to hard to decipher to which of the above-mentioned terms this critique relates to – even though it is easily applicable to both. The ambiguity of the imposed question became structural method used throughout the project. I will use the Walter Benjamin´s remark on the origin of the *golden cannons* as a speculative springboard to my further argument.

> "Had the French gone to war with golden cannons, or had we first taken the gold from them and then used it to cast cannons?"
>
> (Benjamin, 1932, p.46-47)

The dissonance between the base and the mass resting upon it becomes apparent once you metaphorically sever the respective parts of the sculpture and try to rearrange them. While the body already displays a noticeable influence of post-modernist methodology, the base remains within the framework of a purely modernist approach. This tension is further amplified by the decision to manufacture them as a material monolith. I would like to mention here that the question of a base was still a highly discussed topic amongst the academics of the time – and to confess my love to anything made of cast aluminium. Yet, considering Venkov's formal decisions, the sculpture's surroundings and history; a new angle to-be-examined arises. Does the plinth serve as a support structure of propulsion – a base that the mass can rest upon before the intended transition? Or is it a burden, permanently fixed to its body, letting only its sight reach the beyond? I wonder what would have happened if the sculpture somehow overcame its regenerative preparations and finally lift off.

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